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SAVE THE VOTER
Mamata waves a 'defective' voter list

WEST BENGAL

Mamata Fights SIR With AI

The TMC claims to unearth anomalies in the voter list by marrying technology with ground power

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IN INDIA'S DEMOCRACY, the electorate is primary capital. And the means of controlling this resource these days, it seems, is statistical. It was therefore inevitable, in the day and age of big data, that any exercise involving massive statistical sets would also turn technological. The only unlikely element, at first sight, would seem to be the protagonist: the street-savvy Mamata Banerjee. But the circumstances are compelling enough for her to turn her party, the Trinamool Congress, towards a spot of machine learning.

The West Bengal CM had sounded the alarm around voter lists in her state in early 2025 itself, months before the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bihar. She warned of large-scale anomalies, alleging genuine voters were being deleted while "outsiders" were being quietly added.

But she didn't stop at red-flagging the issue. The Trinamool soon put spurs on an initiative. '*Banglar Voter Raksha*' (BVR), they called it: 'Save Bengal's Voters'. Initially conceived as a defensive measure, it has now evolved into the TMC's technologically most sophisticated campaign, with a key role for Artificial Intelligence (AI). Depending on how it goes, it may even inspire other political actors to follow suit.

Says a senior TMC functionary, "Didi had warned that something was off. The Election Commission denied it, but we used AI and it has zeroed in on about one lakh anomalies." By itself not a big number, it has nevertheless equipped the TMC with a clear and distinct weapon to patrol its territory ahead of the forthcoming SIR, which it sees as a legal ploy to weaken its core vote base. In fact, the party's whole response could be seen as a model of political disaster modelling and preparedness—harnessing the powers of technology, amplified by the sheer strength of boots on the ground.

THE DATA ARMY

Between mid-April and May-end, the TMC launched a massive voter verification drive. Over 80,000 booth-level agents, with 10,000-plus support workers, went door to door across the state, reaching roughly 2-3 million households, cross-checking deletions and duplicate entries. Party sources claim over 98 per cent of its targeted verification had been completed, with 90,000-odd anomalies conclusively identified. The whole process has been designed and executed by TMC's poll advisors, IPAC.

Now, as the EC prepares to roll out Bengal's SIR, the TMC is gearing up for BVR Phase II. This aims to take data vigilance a step further, cross-verify the 2025 rolls with the 2002 voter list. The idea is to detect structural shifts or mass deletions over two decades, offer-